spent many hours bathing, using fragrances and make up in an effort to beautify themselves and be presentable to others.

Maintaining a high level of personal hygiene will help to increase self-esteem and confidence, while minimising the chances of developing imperfections.

5.2 PERSONAL HYGIENE

Keywords: *Personal hygiene, factors, cleanliness.*

5.2.1 Introduction

The word hygiene refers to "The science of health and its maintenance, the prevention of disease, and sanitary practices".

5.2.2 Definition

Personal hygiene is the activity of self-care, including bathing and grooming. This includes the care of the skin, hair, nails, mouth, teeth, eyes, ears, nasal cavities, perineal and genital area.

Cleanliness is a fundamental basic human right. Therefore, if an individual became unwell, either physically or mentally and were unable to meet their own hygiene needs, they may require someone else to assist them in such needs, this is where the nurse's responsibility is vital for the patient.

Personal Hygiene



5.2.3 Factors influencing personal hygiene practices.

1. **Development level:** Children learn most of their hygiene practices at home and in their personal environment. They modify their behaviour with other family members. Many of these behaviours stick with them throughout life. The advancing age, hormonal levels and changes in the integumentary system often require hygienic practices.

2. **Cultural background:** Norms related to hygiene practices differ from culture to culture. For example, some cultures place a high value on personal cleanliness. Generally people have a habit of bathing daily where as people from some culture may or may not consider bathing as a daily practice.

3. **Social benefits:** Poor personal hygiene is considered offensive or a sign of illness. Caring for your body regularly can reduce bad odour and improve your personal appearance, subsequently improving others' perceptions of you.

4. **Socio economic status:** Financial status often affects a person' s ability to purchase hygiene products, eg. soap, shampoo, tooth brush.

5. **Religion:** Some religions observe specific rules related to personal hygiene. For example, certain rules for women during their menstrual periods.

6. **Health status:** Persons who are ill are often unable to attend to the personal hygienic activities, either because they have a low energy supply or a specific physical deficit.

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